

The Signal Nobody Told You Was Dying

Why the summary email stopped working, and what it says about every sales behavior that's next.

For years I tracked one number more closely than any metric my CRM could generate. When I sent a summary email after a sales call, prospects who responded closed at around 80%. Prospects who didn't respond closed at around 24%. I trained reps on it. I wrote about it. I built it into my post-call process as a non-negotiable habit.

Then AI made it worthless overnight.

Not because the tactic was bad. Because every rep on the planet suddenly had the same capability I did, whether they cared about the call or not. A sales rep who barely listened, a rep who spent the call half-distracted, a rep who couldn't have told you the prospect's industry if you asked, could now generate a polished, structured, accurate-sounding summary email in under ten seconds. The effort was gone. And with it, the meaning.

Jeff Hoffman told me years ago that summary emails made reps look like admins. I disagreed. I thought he was missing something important. I was wrong. He was seeing something I wasn't ready to see yet. The summary email never worked because it summarized well. It worked because sending a good one was hard enough that most reps didn't bother. That difficulty was the point.

“When the difficulty disappeared, so did the signal.”

WHAT A SIGNAL ACTUALLY IS

Here's the simplest way to understand what happened. A signal works because it is hard to fake. When something becomes easy to fake, the signal stops working. That's it.

Michael Spence won a Nobel Prize in economics for formalizing this idea in 1973. His argument was that credentials and costly behaviors carry information precisely because they require real investment. The moment the cost collapses, the information collapses with it.

This is not a technology story. It's a mechanics story. The technology just happened to trigger the mechanics.

Anais Galdin and Jesse Silbert documented this process empirically in a 2025 paper studying what happened to freelance hiring on Freelancer.com after AI writing tools became widely available. Before those tools, a customized, carefully written proposal was worth real money to employers. Workers with proposals one standard deviation above average in customization quality enjoyed the same hiring boost as workers who bid **\$26 less** for the job. After the AI writing tool launched, that premium collapsed. In their counterfactual model, workers in the top quintile of ability were hired **19% less** often, and workers in the bottom quintile were hired **14% more**

often compared to the pre-AI equilibrium. The market became less meritocratic not because workers got worse, but because the signal that identified the best workers stopped working. The summary email is my version of that story. It isn't unique to me. And the pattern is not finished.

THIS ISN'T AN ISOLATED TACTIC

Here is where I want to say something I haven't said publicly before, because I've been thinking about the summary email as a specific thing that broke rather than as an example of something bigger. The summary email was the first clearly visible case of a pattern that is now coming for other sales behaviors.

Every sales behavior that once required genuine skill, effort, or care to execute well is now a candidate for the same collapse. Not all of them will collapse at the same speed. Not all of them will collapse completely. But the mechanism is identical, and it doesn't care which tactic is next on the list.

Consider what's already under pressure. Personalized outreach was supposed to prove that a rep had actually researched the prospect. Autobound and other platforms report that deeply personalized, signal-driven emails can still reach double-digit reply rates. Real personalization built on genuine buyer signals still carries information. But generic AI personalization is already converging toward noise. Prospectory studied 10,000 B2B sales emails in early 2026 and found AI-generated outreach averaged **8.2%** reply rates against **11.7%** for experienced, human-written emails. In healthcare, the gap widened sharply: AI hit 5.4% while human-written outreach reached 14.8%. The market for trust-sensitive conversations is already differentiating.

The counterargument worth taking seriously is that this dynamic has always existed. Better tools have always democratized previously rare capabilities, and the market has always adapted. That's true. But the adaptation has usually been gradual enough that new signals emerged before the old ones fully collapsed. What's different now is the speed and breadth of the collapse. Multiple signals are losing information value simultaneously, across the same population of buyers, in the same compressed window. The market may not have time to find substitutes before the noise floor rises.

THE PART THE DATA DOESN'T SETTLE

A fair objection to everything above is that Galdin and Silbert studied freelance hiring, not B2B sales. Their market works differently. Buyers in B2B sales have substitute signals that don't exist in freelance hiring: references, executive sponsorship, procurement behavior, and whether a champion is willing to advocate internally. Those signals are harder to manufacture with AI. That objection is correct, and it matters. There is no controlled B2B sales study that proves buyers perceive AI-generated seller behavior as less trustworthy in the same structured way Galdin and Silbert proved it for freelance proposals. The structural analogy holds. The direct proof doesn't exist yet.

But here's what the email reply data does show. Human-written outreach still outperforms AI-generated outreach in the industries where trust is the primary purchase barrier. The gap narrows in lower-stakes contexts and widens in high-trust ones. That's not proof of the mechanism. It's consistent with it. And the more important question isn't whether the data proves buyers consciously distrust AI-generated behavior. It's whether the behavior still differentiates the rep who sent it from any other rep. If it doesn't, the signal is gone regardless of how buyers explain their choices.

WHEN EFFORT STOPPED BEING PROOF

The tension underneath all of these discussions is the one nobody in sales leadership is comfortable sitting with. We built most of our coaching, our inspection processes, and our quality metrics around visible effort as a proxy for seller quality. Summary emails sent. Follow-ups completed. Prep documents filed. Outreach volume. Meeting recaps delivered.

Those proxies worked because effort was costly. Now the cost is near zero for a growing list of behaviors, and the proxies have become measurements of output rather than capability. A rep who generates 200 AI-assisted follow-ups is not demonstrating the same thing a rep who wrote 40 thoughtful ones used to demonstrate. They may not be demonstrating anything about their judgment at all.

“When the cost of faking a behavior reaches zero, the behavior stops telling you anything about the person who performed it.”

That sentence is what I keep coming back to. Not as a warning about AI. As a structural fact about information. If you can't distinguish the rep who genuinely listened from the rep who had a bot take notes, you don't have a signal. You have activity data.

WHAT STILL COSTS SOMETHING

The behaviors that remain costly to fake are the ones that happen in real time, in front of another human being, where no tool can substitute for the judgment of the person in the room. Listening well enough to change direction mid-call is one of those behaviors. Asking the question that wasn't on the prep list because something the buyer said made it necessary. Recognizing that the stated objection isn't the real objection. Knowing when to push and when to let silence do the work. Getting a genuine commitment before the call ends because you earned it, not because you asked for it on a slide.

These aren't nostalgic skills. They're the behaviors that remain informationally valuable precisely because AI can't produce them. A rep who consistently gets prospects to commit to real next steps before the call ends is still demonstrating their value. The defined next step is harder to fake than a polished reply to a summary email, which is precisely why it replaced the summary email as the signal I actually track.

The GIVE/GET framework I've been using and teaching, from *Driving to Close*, was designed as a system that doesn't depend on any individual signal. Now I understand why that design matters more than I originally articulated. A system built around genuine buyer commitment rather than seller-side effort doesn't collapse when the cost of producing effort falls. Commitment from the buyer is still costly for them. That makes it information.

What I'm still sitting with, and what I don't think has a clean answer yet, is whether the skills that remain hard to fake are measurable with the tools sales leaders currently have. If visible effort was the best proxy available for seller quality, and visible effort no longer means what it used to, then measuring seller quality just got significantly harder.

That's the question this pattern raises for the people running sales teams. If the old signals are going quiet, what should a sales leader actually trust now? That's what I'm working through next.

NOTES

Spence signaling theory: Michael Spence, “Job Market Signaling,” Quarterly Journal of Economics (1973); Nobel Prize in Economic Sciences, 2001.

Freelance hiring study: Anais Galdin and Jesse Silbert, 2025 empirical study of AI writing tools and hiring outcomes on Freelancer.com.

Outreach reply-rate data: Autobound platform reporting on personalized, signal-driven email performance; Prospective study of 10,000 B2B sales emails, early 2026.